Robot Dolphins

Animatronic models have come a long way since their inception back in the 60s. Then, the first audio animatronics debuted in Disneyland. Since then they've seen plenty of use, mostly in movies and theme parks. Usually, you can tell when something is animatronic. They have fixed cycles and follow the same routine when they're active. Edge Innovations' Roger Holzberg, however, has animatronics that are hard to tell apart from the real deal. The robotic dolphin weighs 550lbs (around 250kgs), is 8.5 feet long, and has skin made out of the medical-grade silicon, so it feels like real skin. On a single charge, the dolphin can swim for 8-10 hours. It has an AI which dictates its behaviour, which is impressively dolphin-like, from the way it interacts with objects, to even coming up to breath four times a minute. The robot dolphin comes with two modes, exhibition mode, where it explores around its designated area, and an education mode, where it can be controlled by an animator. These robot dolphins cost between $3 million to $5 million. While that's pretty pricey, over the long run, they actually do make up for themselves since you've done away with animal husbandry, feeding, water circulation, temperature control, waste disposal, veterinarian bills etc.

Noveto SoundBeamer

Beaming sound seems like a really cool concept. It is. Imagine not having to wear headphones and having the sounds beam directly to your ears. This is tech that's in use, but in extremely limited scenarios. Israeli company Noveto is all set to pounce on the tech and take it to market as soon as next year. They have a prototype device that's out now. The device has sensors on it which can track listerner's ears, it also has dual transducer arrays which direct the audio to just outside of the ear canals. The audio is ultrasonic before they hit the canal, where they become audible. The way the tech works, nobody else will be able to hear the sound, even if they're in proximity of the device. Noveto has teamed up with Foxconn and China Euro Vehicle Technology AB in order to shrink the product's footprint and have it ready to go commercial sometime in December 2021. They're also hoping to integrate the tech with things such as home theatre, home fitness, video conferencing and more. There's also no information on potential pricing, more should be revealed when we're closer to the commercial release date.

BMW Electric Wingsuit

BMW and Designworks have collaborated to create a wingsuit that utilises BMW's electric vehicle capabilities. The result is something straight out of science fiction. Air sports pioneer, Peter Salzman also had a hand in the design of the wingsuit. Being a professional skydiver and BASE jumper who often employs wingsuits, his input was key. His goal was to be able go further and faster than conventional wingsuits would allow. They definitely managed to accomplish that. The electric wingsuit boosts flight, and allows him to achieve speeds of 300km/h, which is insane. Normal wingsuits can only achieve horizontal speeds of up to 100 km/h. That's 3x the speed!

The suit is powered by a chest mounted rig that produces an output of 15 kW. This is divided between two carbon impellers that spin at 25,000 RPM and produce thrust for five minutes. That's more than enough to achieve speeds and distances on a wingsuit that would never have been possible before.